ERA 16

A Nation Divided

1920 – 1929

Nativism · the Klan · Scopes · Prohibition

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

Why did the modern, urban 1920s spark such a fierce cultural and political backlash?

KEY TERMS

Immigration quotas · Sacco & Vanzetti · the revived Klan · the Scopes Trial · Prohibition

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 7.8 · AMSCO Ch. 7.8

TWO AMERICAS COLLIDE

A Clash of Cultures

Two Americas

Traditional America

Rural · looking back

- Small-town, Protestant, and native-born.
- Defended **fundamentalist** faith and old moral codes.
- Feared immigrants, cities, and rapid change.

Modern America

Urban · looking forward

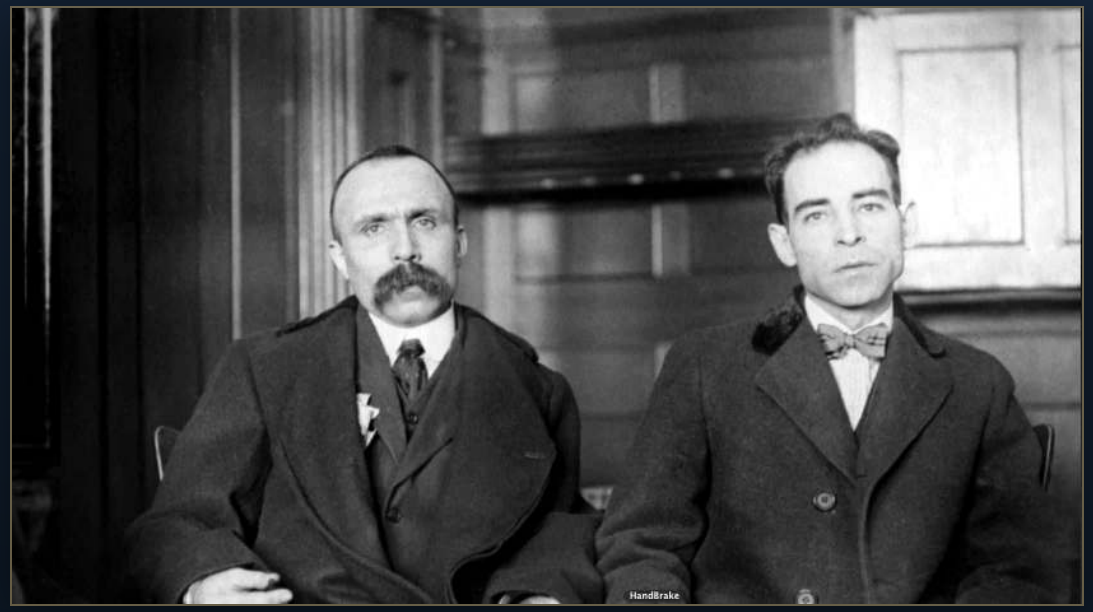
- City-dwelling, diverse, and cosmopolitan.
- Embraced **modernism**, science, and new freedoms.
- Home to immigrants, jazz, and the New Woman.

Nativism & Immigration Restriction

- Postwar fear and the **Red Scare** fed a surge of **nativism**.
- The **Emergency Quota Act** (1921) and **National Origins Act** (1924) slashed immigration.
- New **quotas** targeted Southern and Eastern Europeans and barred most Asians.



Sacco & Vanzetti



- Two Italian immigrant anarchists were convicted of murder on thin evidence.
- Their trial became a cause célèbre for the political left.
- Executed in 1927, they symbolized the era's **nativism** and fear of radicals.

Hooded Reaction

The Klan Revived

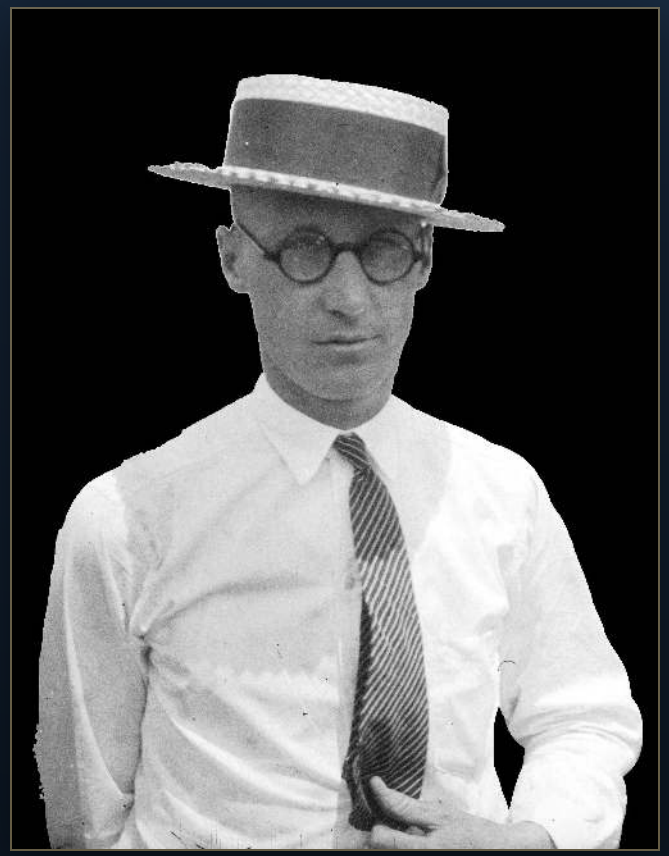
- A new **Ku Klux Klan** surged to millions of members—even outside the South.
- It targeted Black Americans, Catholics, Jews, and immigrants alike.
- Its power reflected the decade's deep anxieties about a changing nation.



SECTION

Faith vs. Science

The Scopes 'Monkey' Trial



- Teacher **John Scopes** was tried for teaching **evolution** in Tennessee.
- It pitted **fundamentalism** (**Bryan**) against **modernism** (**Darrow**).
- The 1925 trial dramatized the clash between faith and science.

Prohibition & Its Failure

- The **18th Amendment** and **Volstead Act** banned alcohol nationwide.
- **Bootlegging**, **speakeasies**, and **organized crime** (**Al Capone**) boomed instead.
- The 'noble experiment' failed—and was repealed by the **21st Amendment** in 1933.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

A Nation Divided

1. Postwar fear drove **nativism**, immigration **quotas**, the **Sacco & Vanzetti** case, and a revived **Klan**.
2. The **Scopes Trial** dramatized the clash between **fundamentalism** and **modernism**.
3. **Prohibition** fueled crime and hypocrisy—and was ultimately repealed, exposing the limits of legislating morality.

DISCUSS & APPLY

A Nation Divided

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how postwar fears fueled **nativism** and immigration restriction in the 1920s.

COMPARISON

Compare the values of **traditional, rural America** and **modern, urban America**.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did the failure of **Prohibition** reveal the limits of legislating morality?

Up next — **Class 45: The Great Depression** (the crash, its causes & Hoover)